

Arjun and the Hiring Backlog

The Founder

Arjun Mehta is the founder of Kargo, a Series A logistics SaaS company based in Mumbai. Kargo helps mid-sized freight forwarders automate shipment tracking, documentation, and carrier coordination - the operational layer that most Indian logistics companies still run on spreadsheets and WhatsApp groups. They closed their Series A in early 2026 and are scaling from 40 people to 70 by December.

There is no HR function at Kargo. Arjun is the hiring manager for every open role.

The Problem

Two roles have been open since July: Product Manager and Senior Product Manager. Both report directly to Arjun - there is no Head of Product yet. Eleven weeks in: sixty applications received, nineteen opened, zero offers made.

At Series A, a company scaling to 70 people cannot afford an eleven-week hiring freeze at the product leadership layer. Every week these roles stay open is a week the engineering team operates without PM ownership - sprint priorities drift, roadmap decisions get deferred, and the growth targets Arjun committed to his investors begin to look like aspiration rather than plan. Kargo is burning runway. The roles are not filling. The cost is compounding.

Two strong candidates who reached out in August got a "let's chat" reply. Neither conversation happened.

The problem is not the volume of applications. The problem is that every review starts from scratch. Arjun looks at CVs late at night when he has forty-five minutes between things. He shortlists on instinct and passes on instinct. There is no record of why anyone was shortlisted or passed over - no notes, no criteria, no rationale he could hand to someone else. The decisions exist only in his head, and even he could not reconstruct most of them.

The deeper issue sits upstream of the review process. Arjun is evaluating candidates against the job spec. But the spec describes the role - it does not predict who will succeed in it. His eight past hires did not match the spec especially well. They had something in common that the spec never asked for, and that pattern has never been surfaced or named. Every week Arjun spends hiring from gut feel is a week the real signal sits buried in his own history.

What He Wants

Arjun has a simple picture in his head: make an offer. That is the only measure of success that matters at this point - not a cleaner process, not better record-keeping. An offer, to the right person, before the year runs out and the targets he set with his investors become impossible to hit.

What he needs first is a shortlist he can trust. Trust means something specific here. Not a list of people who match the job spec - he has been trying that for eleven weeks. A list of people who look like his best hires:

the ones still at Kargo and thriving, not the ones who left or were let go. That pattern exists inside his own history. It has never been extracted or applied.

When that shortlist is in front of him, Arjun wants to be able to act without managing what comes next. For each candidate, he needs enough to make a confident call - who they are, why the system ranked them here, what to probe if he moves forward. His job is to look, decide, and move. Everything downstream of that decision should happen without him chasing it, drafting it, or remembering to send it. The candidates he does not move forward should hear back too. Nineteen people have had their application opened at Kargo and heard nothing. That is the reputation he is building right now, by accident.

The system recommends. Arjun decides. That decision is the last thing he touches.

What He's Providing

Arjun has given you access to three folders:

applications/ - Sixty CVs across two roles: Product Manager and Senior Product Manager. Mixed formats.

hires/ - Eight past hire profiles. Each profile contains the role they were hired into, what stood out in their application, what the interview revealed, and a one-line outcome note. The outcomes are mixed. The calibration requires that.

Name	Role	Joined	Last Rating
Rohan Desai	Head of Engineering	Jul 2022	Exceeds Expectations
Sunita Krishnamurthy	Operations Lead	Jan 2023	Exceeds Expectations
Vikram Nair	Product Manager	Jun 2023	Meets Expectations
Aditya Shetty	Sales Lead	Aug 2023	Exceeds Expectations
Preetham Rao	Backend Engineer	Feb 2024	Below Expectations
Meghna Tiwari	Customer Success Manager	Aug 2024	Exceeds Expectations
Lavanya Iyer	Product Manager	Apr 2025	Exceeds Expectations
Rahul Bose	Growth & Marketing Lead	Jun 2025	Meets Expectations

jds/ - The Job Descriptions of the 2 roles that Arjun is hiring for

Before You Come to Class on 28 Sept

Read this brief carefully. Using it as your source material, prepare the following and complete them before coming to class:

1. **Automation Brief:** Write down the 'Why' - Pain, User, Outcome - and map The Journey Today.
2. **Nine Checks:** Work through all nine checks with evidence from the case. Identify the Cut: the one thing Arjun has described wanting that a check stops you from building.
3. **Components Map:** Map the workflow using the Trigger → Input → Context → Processing → AI → Output structure from your session notes.
4. **Resend Account:** Create a free account at resend.com and generate your API key. A step-by-step guide will be shared on the course portal.

Session L4 on 28 Sept opens with your Automation Brief and Components Map. Come ready to defend both.

Kargo, Arjun Mehta, and all associated data in this case are fictional. The business problems are constructed for learning purposes.